PRACTITIONER HANDBOOKS · B2

Personal Mentor’s Guide

The full one-to-one companion for Personal Mentors: the role, getting started, the member’s journey stage by stage, the conversations that matter, warning signs, and support for the mentor.

Audience	Personal Mentors
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Companions	Personal Mentor’s Short Guide (B2a) · Mentor Meeting Guide · Stage Checklists

Foreword

Being asked to serve as a Personal Mentor is one of the most meaningful things you can do in Freemasonry. You are not being asked to be an expert, a teacher, or a guide to all things Masonic. You are being asked to be something far simpler - and far more important: a friend.

This guide has been produced to support you in that role. It is practical and deliberately focused on the things that matter most in day-to-day mentoring: what to say, when to say it, how to recognise when a Brother needs more support, and who to turn to if you need help yourself.

The Provincial Mentoring Framework is clear that retention - keeping good men in Freemasonry - is not achieved through programmes or targets. It is achieved through culture: a culture in which every Brother feels welcomed, prepared, guided, and genuinely valued as an individual. You are a central part of that culture.

Mentoring in Hertfordshire rests on four principles: Prepare, Guide, Support, and Enlighten. Each of them applies to you as a Personal Mentor. You prepare your mentee for the ceremonies and stages ahead; you guide him with honest and accurate information; you support him through whatever challenges arise; and you help him discover the depth and richness of Freemasonry over time.

None of this requires perfection. It requires presence, patience, and genuine interest in the wellbeing of another person.

Please make full use of this guide, and never hesitate to speak to your Lodge Mentor or the Provincial Grand Mentor's office if a situation arises that you are unsure how to handle. You are not expected to manage everything alone - and asking for support is always the right thing to do.

Wes Pierce

Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor, Province of Hertfordshire

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1 Your Role as a Personal Mentor

As a Personal Mentor, your role is to provide individual, one-to-one support to a specific member throughout his Masonic journey. You are his first point of contact for questions, his guide through unfamiliar territory, and - most importantly - his friend within the Lodge.

You are not expected to know everything. You are not a teacher, a lecturer, or a ceremonial expert. Your most important quality is genuine interest in the person you are supporting: listening to him, understanding his needs, and being present when he needs you.

Your role IS	Your role IS NOT
A friend and trusted guide	The sole expert on all things Masonic
A first point of contact for questions	The only person who can help him
Someone who keeps in regular touch	A ceremonial coach or ritual instructor
A listener who notices when things change	Someone who reports on or monitors him
A bridge to the Lodge and Province	A replacement for the Lodge Mentor

The Lodge Mentor co-ordinates and oversees mentoring across the whole Lodge. You are the person who does the day-to-day work with the individual member. Both roles are essential; they work together rather than in isolation.

The duration of the relationship is open-ended. You may support someone through their early degrees and then find the relationship naturally evolves into a broader friendship. You may be asked to continue supporting someone through progressive office and beyond. Follow the lead of the member and the guidance of the Lodge Mentor.

> **Key Principle.** Mentoring is not a programme. It is a relationship. The relationship you build with your mentee - built on trust, consistency, and genuine care - is the single most powerful thing you can offer him.

2 Getting Started

Being Assigned a Mentee

When you are asked to serve as a Personal Mentor, the Lodge Mentor will introduce you to the member you will be supporting. Before you meet, it is worth taking a moment to think about what you know about him already, and what you will need to find out:

- How did he come to Freemasonry? Who proposed him?

- What do you know about his background, interests, and occupation?
- Does he have a partner or family who should be involved in social occasions?
- Are there any practical constraints to be aware of - geography, work patterns, travel?

Where a candidate has been proposed by someone you know well, a brief conversation with the Proposer can be invaluable. The Proposer already has a relationship of trust with the candidate and can provide helpful background. In many cases, the Proposer makes an excellent Personal Mentor for precisely this reason.

Your First Meeting

Your first meeting with your mentee sets the tone for the whole relationship. It does not need to be formal. A coffee, a meal, or a brief chat after a Lodge meeting are all perfectly appropriate. The aim is simply to establish a comfortable connection.

In your first meeting, aim to:

- Introduce yourself properly - your background, your time in Freemasonry, your own journey
- Make clear that you are there to help him and are genuinely interested in his experience
- Explain simply what a Personal Mentor does: a point of contact, a guide, a friend
- Ask open questions about him: what drew him to Freemasonry, what he hopes to get from it, any concerns he has
- Avoid overwhelming him with information; this is a listening meeting more than a teaching one
- End the meeting by agreeing how and when you will next be in touch

> **Good Practice.** Tell him something about your own early experience of Freemasonry: what surprised you, what you found confusing, what you came to love. It reassures him that uncertainty is normal and that you understand how he may be feeling.

Setting the Tone

From the outset, convey clearly that:

- There are no stupid questions - every new member has them, and he should feel completely at ease asking anything
- He can contact you at any time if something is worrying him or he is unsure about something
- Freemasonry is meant to be enjoyable, and if something is not enjoyable, you want to know about it
- He will never be pressured or pushed into anything before he feels ready

These assurances are not just courtesies. They are the foundation of a mentoring relationship that will work when it is tested - and every mentoring relationship will be tested at some point.

3 The Member's Journey: What to Cover and When

The guidance in this section sets out the key conversations and actions that good mentoring should include at each stage of the member's journey. These are prompts, not a rigid script. Use your knowledge of the individual to decide what he needs, when he needs it, and how best to have the conversation.

Before Initiation

If you are assigned as Personal Mentor before the ballot, your role at this stage is light but important: to build a friendly relationship and ensure the candidate is warmly prepared for what lies ahead.

- Meet him socially with other Lodge members whenever possible before his Initiation
- Involve his partner or family in social occasions where appropriate
- Answer any questions he has openly and honestly - there is no need for mystery or secrecy about what Freemasonry is or what the evening will involve practically
- Ensure he knows what to wear, what to bring, and what to expect on the night
- Contact him the day before or on the morning of his Initiation to offer reassurance

> **Remember.** A well-prepared candidate arrives relaxed and curious. An unprepared one arrives anxious and uncertain. The difference is almost entirely down to the quality of the relationship he has with those who are with him.

The Initiation Evening

On the evening of Initiation, your presence and warmth matter enormously:

- Introduce the candidate to the Tyler and the Junior Deacon before the meeting; both can reassure him and help him feel supported while he is outside
- Be seated as close to the Initiate as possible during the meeting so that you can provide quiet explanation and reassurance as events unfold
- Prepare him before the Festive Board: how to conduct Masonic Fire, the order of the toasts, and what he will be asked to say. Provide him with a draft speech well in advance that he can adapt
- Ensure he is not left alone or confused at any point during the evening

After Initiation: Your First One-to-One

The first meeting between you and your mentee after his Initiation is one of the most important conversations you will have. It should take place before the next Lodge meeting - ideally within a week or two of his Initiation.

Begin by simply asking how he felt about the evening. Let him talk. Then gently work through the topics below, at his pace, not yours.

Topics to Cover After Initiation

The following topics should be covered in the period following Initiation - not necessarily all at once, but progressively across your first few meetings:

The Ceremony of Initiation **Review what happened and why - the form and significance of the ceremony** **Discuss the Obligation, the Investiture with the Apron, and what they mean** **Explain the teachings of the First Degree, particularly charity and benevolence** **Ensure he understands the Signs, Token, and Word and can give them correctly according to the Lodge's custom and ritual** **Explain the Sign of Reverence and its use during prayers**
The Organisation of the Lodge Describe the seating arrangement and location of the principal officers Explain the function of each officer - the Master, Wardens, Deacons, Almoner, Secretary, Director of Ceremonies, Treasurer, Charity Steward Show him how to recognise officers by their collar jewels Explain the structure of Freemasonry under the English Constitution: Lodge, Province, Grand Lodge
Masonic Etiquette and Protocol The Three Risings and what may be discussed under each How to conduct Masonic Fire correctly - give him the opportunity to practise before any Festive Board The order and significance of toasts at the Festive Board The procedure for ballots: by show of hands, by ballot slips, by ballot box How to address the Master and fellow Brethren
Charitable Work An introduction to the charitable work of Freemasonry at Lodge, Provincial, and Grand Lodge level The ways in which he can contribute: Lodge charity, Provincial appeals, national charities The importance of charity as a foundational principle rather than an obligation
Practical Matters Introduce him to the test questions he will need to answer before his Passing Review the Initiate's Guide with him and answer any questions it raises Encourage him to attend the Lodge of Instruction and advise him how to do so Introduce him to Solomon and encourage him to explore it at his own pace Confirm he has the contact details he needs for the Lodge Secretary and yourself

Between Degrees: Making the Most of the Time

When the Lodge meets in a higher Degree, the Entered Apprentice is excluded from that meeting. This time is not dead time - it is one of the best opportunities

for structured Masonic education, and the quality of a mentor's use of it makes a significant difference to how informed and engaged the member feels.

- Arrange to spend time with him on the evening of the Lodge meeting, or at another mutually convenient time
- Use the time to explore topics he has questions about: the history of Freemasonry, the symbolism of the First Degree, the layout and symbolism of the Lodge room
- Encourage him to use Solomon between meetings to explore areas of interest
- Ensure he is working on the test questions for his Passing
- Simply keeping in regular contact during this period matters enormously - it tells him he has not been forgotten

> **Key Principle.** The role of an Entered Apprentice can feel quite lonely. Meetings happen around and above him. Regular, friendly contact from you during this period - even just a brief message to check in - makes the difference between a member who feels included and one who quietly drifts.

After Passing to Fellow Craft

After his Passing, meet with him as soon as convenient. Your conversation should include:

- A review of the ceremony: what happened and its significance
- An explanation of why he was not hoodwinked: he was already a member of the Lodge, proved by answering the test questions correctly
- A discussion of the "Liberal Arts and Sciences" and their relevance to everyday life
- The correct method of giving the Sign, Token, and Word of a Fellow Craft in your Lodge
- The different Masonic aprons, their significance, and when he will need a Master Mason's apron
- Ensure he has received the Fellow Craft's Guide and discuss any questions it raises
- Begin preparing him for the Third Degree, including the test questions he will need to learn
- Encourage him to visit another Lodge to witness a Passing ceremony

After Raising to Master Mason

The Raising is a significant moment. Meet with him soon afterwards for a considered conversation:

- Discuss the essence of the Third Degree and its central teaching
- Explain the correct method of giving the Grip and the Five Points of Fellowship as taught in your Lodge
- Explain how to sign in correctly when visiting another Lodge
- Explain that different Lodges work differently; he should observe carefully and never pass critical comment on another Lodge's working
- Discuss the etiquette of responding to the Visitors' Toast, and the importance of thanking hosts promptly and warmly
- Ensure he knows the structure of Grand Lodge, Provincial Grand Lodge, and their principal Rulers
- Ensure he has received the Master Mason's Guide and address any questions it raises

> **Good Practice.** Arrange for him to witness a Raising ceremony in another Lodge as soon as convenient. Watching the ceremony from the outside is one of the most valuable experiences a new Master Mason can have.

Life as a Master Mason

The weeks and months after Raising are a formative period. Your mentoring during this time shapes whether the member becomes actively engaged or begins to drift.

- Encourage him to attend the Lodge of Instruction regularly and ensure he knows when and where it meets
- Encourage visiting other Lodges - across the Province and further afield
- Introduce him to Provincial events: meetings, social occasions, and Light Blue events
- Help him discover areas of Freemasonry that genuinely interest him, and support him in exploring them
- Begin gentle, unhurried conversations about the Royal Arch in due course - see Section 4
- Be alert to any signs of reduced enthusiasm or engagement - see Section 7

Into Progressive Office and Beyond

When your mentee is offered his first office, continue to support him:

- Confirm that he is genuinely ready and willing - never encourage him to accept office before he feels confident
- Ensure he understands the responsibilities and ritual requirements of the office and has the support he needs to meet them
- Continue checking in regularly as he progresses through the offices
- Be attentive to any signs of anxiety about ritual delivery or meeting management
- Continue the relationship beyond the Chair - Past Masters often need mentoring support too, particularly in rediscovering a sense of purpose and contribution after leaving the Chair

4 Conversations That Matter

Good mentoring is built on good conversations. You do not need special training to have them - but a few simple principles will help you make the most of the time you spend with your mentee.

Asking Good Questions

The most effective conversations begin with open questions - questions that invite reflection rather than a simple yes or no answer. Examples include:

- "How did you find the meeting last night?"
- "Is there anything from the ceremony that you'd like to talk through?"
- "How are you getting on with the Lodge of Instruction?"
- "Is there anything about Freemasonry you've been wondering about?"
- "How are things generally - is everything alright?"

The last question matters particularly. A mentor who asks how things are generally - and means it - is far more likely to hear about a problem before it becomes a crisis.

Listen more than you talk. Resist the urge to fill silences immediately. If your mentee is thinking, let him think.

Talking About Difficulties

There will be times when your mentee raises a difficulty: a concern about something in the Lodge, a feeling of not fitting in, trouble learning ritual, or personal circumstances that are affecting his involvement.

In those moments:

- Listen without judgement. Do not immediately try to solve the problem or dismiss the concern.
- Acknowledge what he has said: "I understand why you feel that way." "That sounds frustrating."
- Ask what would help, rather than assuming you know.
- Be honest if you are unsure of the answer, and never speculate or guess on matters of Lodge governance or Masonic practice.
- Where a difficulty is beyond your role to address - a Lodge dispute, a welfare concern, or anything that feels serious - speak to the Lodge Mentor promptly. This is not a failure; it is exactly what the Lodge Mentor is there for.

> **Important.** If your mentee discloses something that raises a genuine welfare concern - about his health, finances, family, or personal safety - speak to the Lodge Almoner and Lodge Mentor as soon as possible. You are not expected to handle welfare matters alone.

Talking About the Royal Arch

The Royal Arch is described by UGLE as "the completion of Pure Antient Masonry," and it is an important part of a Master Mason's journey. When the time is right, you should introduce the subject to your mentee.

The right time is when:

- He has had sufficient time to consolidate his understanding of the Craft
- He has expressed curiosity about it, or asked questions that naturally lead there
- He has the capacity - in time and commitment - for an additional degree

When you raise it:

- Be informative rather than persuasive. Explain what the Royal Arch is, what it involves, and what the additional commitment means.
- Reassure him that the Craft is complete and valuable in itself; the Royal Arch is an enrichment, not a requirement.
- Never create the impression that he is an incomplete Freemason without it.
- If he expresses interest, involve the Lodge Mentor, who can co-ordinate the next steps.

5 Supporting Learning

Your mentee's learning will take two forms: the guided learning that Freemasonry requires - test questions, ritual, protocol, and ceremony - and the personal learning that he chooses to pursue out of his own curiosity and interest. Both are important, and your role is to encourage and enable both.

Solomon

Solomon is UGLE's online learning platform and the primary authoritative resource for Masonic education in England. You should familiarise yourself with it and recommend it actively to your mentee.

- Solomon contains accurate, UGLE-approved guidance on all aspects of Masonic life
- It is available online at solomon.ugle.org.uk and can be accessed from home
- It is an excellent resource for filling the time when your mentee is excluded from Lodge meetings in a higher Degree
- Direct your mentee to Solomon rather than to unverified online content, which may be inaccurate, outdated, or from a different Masonic tradition

The Lodge of Instruction

Regular attendance at the Lodge of Instruction is one of the most effective ways for a member to build confidence, learn ritual, and develop a deeper sense of belonging to the Lodge. Your encouragement makes a significant difference.

- Ensure your mentee knows when and where the Lodge of Instruction meets, and how to attend for the first time
- Offer to accompany him to his first meeting at the Lodge of Instruction if that would help him feel more comfortable
- Encourage him to attend consistently, even when he does not yet hold a lodge office

Visiting Other Lodges

Visiting other Lodges is one of the most valuable and often underused opportunities in Freemasonry. Brethren who visit regularly are more confident, more informed, and more likely to remain committed long-term.

- Encourage your mentee to visit from the moment he becomes a Master Mason, if not before
- Offer to accompany him on his first visit to another Lodge, especially if he is uncertain about the etiquette

- Help him understand that visiting is not just permitted but positively encouraged
- Introduce him to Provincial events, meetings, and social occasions beyond his own Lodge

6 Keeping a Simple Record

You are not expected to maintain formal documentation about your mentee. However, keeping a simple, brief record of your meetings and conversations has practical benefits: it helps you remember what has been covered, ensures nothing important is missed, and provides a useful handover document if the mentoring arrangement ever needs to change.

A record need only contain:

- The date and nature of each contact (meeting, phone call, message)
- A brief note of topics discussed or actions agreed
- Any concerns or follow-up actions identified

Records should be kept securely and treated with discretion. They should not be shared outside the Lodge Mentor and, where appropriate, the Provincial Grand Mentor's office. If you are uncertain about how to handle any information shared in confidence, speak to the Lodge Mentor before acting on it.

> **Data Protection.** Personal information about your mentee should be handled with care and in accordance with data protection principles. Do not share personal details, family circumstances, or confidential disclosures without the member's knowledge and consent, except where a genuine welfare concern requires it.

7 Recognising Warning Signs

One of your most important contributions as a Personal Mentor is noticing when something has changed for your mentee - and acting on it before a temporary difficulty becomes a permanent one.

The following are signs that a member may be beginning to disengage. None of them, in isolation, is cause for alarm - but a combination of them, or a persistent pattern, warrants a friendly conversation and, if necessary, a word with the Lodge Mentor.

What to watch for	Signs that may indicate a member is beginning to disengage
Attendance	Missing two or more consecutive meetings without explanation Arriving very late or leaving early repeatedly Attending only installations or social events Stopping visiting other Lodges
Participation	Reluctance to accept Lodge work or prepare for office Withdrawal from Lodge conversations and social interaction Missing Lodge of Instruction when holding an office Seeming distracted, disengaged, or unhappy during meetings
Communication	Not responding to your calls, messages, or contact Expressing frustration, disappointment, or disillusionment Mentioning financial or time pressures repeatedly Comparing Freemasonry unfavourably with expectations or other commitments

If you observe any of these signs, the first step is always a warm, friendly, informal contact - not a formal intervention. A phone call, a brief message, or a cup of coffee is usually enough to open the conversation.

If your concern continues, or if what he shares suggests something more serious, speak to the Lodge Mentor promptly. Early action prevents resignation; delayed action rarely does.

> **The Right Question.** The question is always "How can I help?" - never "Why haven't you been attending?" The tone of the conversation makes the difference between a member who feels supported and one who feels judged.

8 Support for You

Personal Mentors are not expected to manage every situation alone. Knowing where to turn when you need support is part of the role.

Your Lodge Mentor	Your first point of contact for any situation involving your mentee. The Lodge Mentor co-ordinates mentoring across the Lodge and can provide advice, support, and, where necessary, escalation. Contact him whenever you are unsure about a situation or feel you need a second opinion.
Provincial Grand Mentor	Available to Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors where a situation requires Provincial-level support or advice. All contact is treated in confidence. Contact via the Provincial Office: mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk
The Lodge Almoner	Where a member's situation involves welfare concerns - health, financial difficulty, bereavement, family circumstances - the Almoner is the appropriate first point of contact. Always involve the Almoner where welfare is a concern.
Monthly Mentoring Calls	The Provincial Grand Mentor hosts a monthly mentoring call open to all Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors in Hertfordshire. These calls are an opportunity to raise questions, share experiences, and hear from the Provincial team.
Solomon (UGLE)	The primary resource for accurate Masonic education. Available at solomon.ugle.org.uk

If you are ever uncertain whether a situation is serious, err on the side of speaking to the Lodge Mentor. It is far better to raise a concern that turns out to be minor than to leave a significant problem unaddressed.

9 Quick Reference: Key Actions at Each Stage

The table below provides a summary of the key actions for a Personal Mentor at each stage of the member's journey. Use it as a checklist and as a reminder of the conversations you should be having.

Before Initiation	**Meet him socially, involve his partner or family where appropriate** **Ensure he is fully prepared for the evening: dress, timing, what to expect** **Contact him the day before to offer reassurance**
Initiation Evening	Introduce him to the Tyler and JD before the meeting Sit close to him; offer quiet explanation as the meeting unfolds Ensure he is prepared for the Festive Board; give him a draft speech in advance

After Initiation (first few weeks)	First one-to-one meeting before the next Lodge meeting Review the ceremony; answer all questions at his pace Cover: Signs/Token/Word, Lodge organisation, etiquette, charity, test questions Introduce him to Solomon and the Initiate's Guide
Between Degrees (EA period)	Keep in regular contact; do not let him feel forgotten Use excluded meetings for Masonic education Ensure he is working on the test questions for his Passing
After Passing (FC)	Review the Passing ceremony and its significance Cover: Signs/Token/Word of FC, aprons, Liberal Arts and Sciences Present and review the Fellow Craft's Guide Encourage a visit to witness a Passing ceremony elsewhere
After Raising (MM)	Review the Raising ceremony and its central teaching Cover: Grip, Five Points, visiting etiquette, Lodge structure Present and review the Master Mason's Guide Encourage visiting other Lodges and attending LoI regularly Encourage attendance at Provincial events
Life as a MM	Introduce Provincial events, Light Blue meetings, wider Masonic life Support him in finding areas of Freemasonry that genuinely interest him Begin gentle conversations about the Royal Arch when the time is right Remain alert to signs of disengagement
Into Office & Beyond	Continue regular contact as he progresses through the offices Be attentive to anxiety about ritual or Lodge management Support him after leaving the Chair in finding continued engagement

> This guide will be reviewed and updated periodically. If you have suggestions for improvement or would like to discuss anything in it, please speak to your Lodge Mentor or contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.
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